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Trust and Involvement in Tourism Social Media and Web-Based Travel Information Sources

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ABSTRACT *While utilisation of electronic social media is increasingly relevant as tourism practices, there is still a deficiency of empirical research on tourists' creation and use of various types of online content. This study maps and explores Scandinavian tourists' perceptions of Web 1.0 and Web 2.0 information sources and scrutinises influence of electronic social media on holidaymakers' information sharing, based on a summer season survey in the mature and well-known destination of Mallorca, Spain. Empirical evidence is presented on perceived trustworthiness of social media platforms and other Internet-based information. The study also examines tourists' involvement in developing and sharing of virtual content. It critically analyses technological mediation through electronic word-of-mouth and involvement factors related to virtual dissemination of travel narratives. Moreover, the paper discusses information intensity, hedonic aspects and utilitarian values of tourist information in relation to interaction aspects of social media, in a context of holiday choices and online booking.*

KEY WORDS: user-generated content, social media, electronic word-of-mouth, perceived trustworthiness

Introduction

Holiday tours have long been among the highlights in many peoples' lives in the Western world, as indicated, for instance, by the space allocated to such events in autobiographies and family life stories such as photo albums (Jacobsen, 1983, pp. 157–158). The pleasure of knowing and sharing information about destinations and other holiday aspects are important parts of the enjoyment of travel (Douglas & Isherwood, 1980, p. 75) and is also vital to reproduction of various social relations, expressed not

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only through post-travel oral accounts but also by way of travel letters and postcards (Graburn, 1977; Knebel, 1960, pp. 146–147), partly to confirm sustained social relations while away from one's everyday surroundings (Jacobsen, 1983, pp. 159–160). Like postcards and letters, recent online media and Web-based networks contribute to maintaining and accumulating social capital; ties to family, friends and acquaintances (Brogan & Smith, 2009; Putnam, 2001). Furthermore, showing and sharing holiday information may provide a sense of identity (Baym, 2010) and may also strengthen cultural capital, that is, wealth in the form of knowledge or ideas, which legitimate continuation of status and superiority (Bourdieu, 1984).

Due to advances of the Internet and electronic social media, traditional creative processes, distribution mechanisms and consumption patterns of sharing of travel stories are being transformed. Availability of social media platforms and technologies allows tourists increasingly to digitise and share online knowledge and information (Buhalis & Law, 2008; Volo, 2010) and also emotions and experiential moments (Jacobsen & Munar, 2012). Such transformations are partly related to Web technologies that provide global reach of content, for instance, videos posted in media-sharing site such as YouTube (Qualman, 2009). Moreover, digital interaction introduces the possibility of anonymity and lack of personal accountability such as unidentified contributions on review sites (Streitfeld, 2011), and it allows for development of virtual communities, creating new forms of social interactions and ties (Kozinets, 1999). Features of these technologies also transform landscapes of mediation in tourism processes, for example, by empowering new-fangled Web-based intermediaries and their customer bases (Dellarocas, 2003). As digitised content can be widely available, it may additionally transform what previously were mainly private social experiences of knowledge sharing into global databases of consumer information that can be managed and analysed by tourism firms and organisations. Finally, Web-based platforms allow for “real-time” recording and sharing of tourism experiences and they are also part of the development of personal virtual identities (Munar, 2010).

Although much research has focused on the impact that tourists' online content may have on the marketplace (Li, Pan, Zhang, & Smith, 2009; Xiang & Gretzel, 2010), it is increasingly relevant also to examine those tourists who create content and how this content is shared. However, up to the early 2010s, there were very few empirical studies providing evidence on tourists' online utilisation and contribution practices (Bronner & de Hoog, 2011). Among emerging major questions that present themselves are the following: What kind of tourists are contributors of social media content? Where and when do tourists share online content?

This paper contributes to the understanding of tourists' social media adoption in technologically advanced markets with high levels of information and communication technologies (ICT) adoption and use, in relation to a mainstream holiday location that is generally well known in Western Europe. The study presents insights into different types of contribution practices according to types of social media (e.g. social networks, review sites, etc.) and levels of perceived trustworthiness of social media sites and it has three main objectives:

- (1) Provide empirical evidence of impact of social media platforms on tourists' knowledge-sharing practices.

- (2) Examine perceived trustworthiness of social media and other Web-based information sources.
- (3) Contribute to expanding the knowledge base on technological mediation and emerging tourism cultures in the context of countries with a high level of ICT adoption and use.

Literature Review

Information and communication technologies impact on many tourism aspects (Buhalis & Law, 2008). The evolution of the Internet and the Web are major factors of change in the tourism and travel industries and in the ways tourists purchase and experience travel aspects. The Web has also been regarded as a threat to the power of organisations (Shih, 2009). For instance, the importance of destination organisations in marketing and promotion may alter due to Internet-related transformations, even if their position is often taken for granted (Cai, Gartner, & Munar, 2009; Morgan, Pritchard, & Pride, 2009; Munar, 2011). Moreover, increased direct sale of travel products on the Internet might empower certain travel businesses such as airlines at the same time as it might challenge intermediaries such as traditional travel agencies and tour operators (Buhalis & Licata, 2002; Marcussen, 2010).

The Internet evolution at the millennium is popularly labelled “Web 2.0” (Musser, O’Reilly, & O’Reilly Radar Team, 2007), a term used to depict an increasingly participatory and interactive Web (Shih, 2009). This advance enables “users to contribute to developing, rating, collaborating and distributing Internet content and customizing Internet applications” (Vickery & Wunsch-Vincent, 2007, p. 9). Expansion of electronic social media is Web 2.0’s main asset (Brogan & Smith, 2009; Li & Bernoff, 2008; Qualman, 2009; Weber, 2009). Social media technologies have led to a change in the locus of control in creation processes of online tourism content, from a Web 1.0 mainly controlled by organisations and corporations towards a more inclusive Web 2.0, which to a large extent is the expression of interaction and participation of end users (Shih, 2009). A popular assumption of social media studies is that besides a “digital divide” due to socio-economic and cultural differences between social strata and nations, there is also a generational divide. The first generation of tourists to grow up with electronic information technology has been called “digital natives” (Prensky, 2001) and the “Net generation” (Tapscott, 2009).

The phenomenon of tourists creating and sharing information online has received increased research attention. Most early studies have focused on exploratory and descriptive issues and a main concern has been development of typologies of electronic social media platforms and content (Enoch & Grossman, 2010; Litvin, Goldsmith, & Pan, 2008; Pudliner, 2007; Schmallegger & Carson, 2008; Wenger, 2008). Such studies show on one side how social media are winning momentum as emerging tourism practices. Then again, they also critically discuss the quality of tourists’ contributions and limitations of online communicative practices (Jacobsen & Munar, 2012; Volo, 2010). Additionally, some studies have looked at motivation factors that impact on tourists’ contributing online behaviour. According to Hsu, Ju, Yen, and Chang (2007), willingness to share knowledge online depends on personal cognition and social influence.

Electronic social media as evolving an interactive technological landscape adopts many different forms. Some of the most popular social media types are wikis (e.g.

Wikitravel), blogs (e.g. Travelblog) and microblogs (e.g. Twitter), social networks (e.g. Facebook), media-sharing sites (e.g. Flickr, YouTube), review sites (e.g. TripAdvisor) and voting sites (e.g. Digg) (Zarella, 2010). Several different ways in which to research such diversity have been proposed. In a study of electronic word-of-mouth, Bronner and de Hoog (2011) suggest that analyses of tourists' contributions can adopt either site-centred or topic-centred approaches. Site-centred research focuses on specific types of platforms (Law, 2006; O'Connor, 2010; Tussyadiah & Fesenmaier, 2008, 2009), while topic-centred approaches do not relate to specific sites and examine certain topics such as the main summer holiday (Bronner & de Hoog, 2011). Nevertheless, a closer look at the literature on tourism social media indicates that this classification is insufficient as one might approach these media separately but also holistically. Several publications have focused on multiple social media platforms and various topics, for instance, virtual communities (Illum, Ivanov, & Liang, 2010), positions of social media in search engines (Xiang & Gretzel, 2010), social media adoption in national markets (Gretzel, Kang, & Lee, 2008) and social media impact on destination branding strategies (Munar, 2011).

Yet another approach for examination of tourism social media is a theoretical framework introduced by Litvin et al. (2008); a categorisation based on level of interaction (asynchronous/synchronous) and communication scope of different platforms. For example, platforms representing asynchronous levels of interaction are blogs and virtual communities (many-to-many), emails (one-to-one or one-to-many) and websites and product review sites (one-to-many), while synchronous interactive technologies encompass instant messaging (one-to-one) and newsgroups (one-to-many). Then again, closer examination of this dual differentiation exhibits some central limitations. For example, emails can be asynchronous but do not have to, and they can have both limited and extensive reach, depending of the network. The same can be said of instant messaging. Indeed, one of the most interesting characteristics of digital social media is that they allow communication with large numbers of people in different locations and at different times. This feature disrupts traditional boundaries in the scope of communication such as division between private and mass communication and exemplifies the difficulty of categorising social media technologies that are highly fluid and have multiple uses.

More complex lines of research deal with new media either as "genres" (Eriksen & Ihlström, 2000) or adopt a comparative approach based on multiple categories. Baym (2010) has proposed a conceptual framework based on seven dimensions that can be used to categorise media: *interactivity*, which indicates different levels of social interactivity enabled by different communicative platforms; *temporal structure*, which reflects upon asynchronous and synchronous practices and real-time features; *social cues*, which examines context richness (e.g. information about personal identities and spatial and environmental contexts); *reach*, which measures the audience that a medium can attain or support; *mobility*, which refers to the extent in which specific media are portable, enabling people to communicate almost regardless of location, and *storage and replicability*, referring to possibilities for recording and reproducing communicative acts.

Two other vital dimensions, not discussed by Baym (2010), are *hierarchy* and *control* of communication. Social media can remove social or cultural communicative

barriers but these media may also establish new hierarchical systems, such as rating systems and classes of users with different access rights. Furthermore, social media show different levels of *control*. Digitised content and user participation can be employed to nurture systems of surveillance of user behaviour and content (Munar, 2011). To borrow from the theorising of Habermas (1989), these platforms have an “ambivalent potential” for control and surveillance and for personal freedom.

Some social media platforms have been very successful, with millions of users and are near ubiquitous in some countries (Qualman, 2009). In the early 2010s, these included social networks (e.g. Facebook), microblogging sites (e.g. Twitter), blogging sites (e.g. Travelblog) and review sites (e.g. TripAdvisor). A holistic perspective seems apposite for studies of such media because they share some related features. First, these media allow for multiple temporal structures as tourists may use networks such as Facebook at the same time as they engage in synchronous chat and in asynchronous photo sharing. Second, a disruptive element of these user-friendly media is that they can achieve massive reach in an instant. Third, digital content can be stored and replicated (e.g. tourists’ hotel reviews). Fourth, the use of these media is becoming increasingly mobile with tourists uploading and accessing user-generated content through mobile technologies (e.g. posting on Twitter from a mobile phone). Fifth, when compared with other traditional mass media such as newspapers or television broadcast, social media encourage high levels of interactivity and participation among users (Xiang & Gretzel, 2010).

Nevertheless, such communicative platforms represent a diversity that calls for increased awareness of complexity in use and adoption of Web technologies. Electronic social networks usually provide social cues that are richer than in other types of platforms such as review sites or media-sharing sites. These networks differ from other interactive media such as wikis also because they augment the making of relationships among their users (Buss & Strauss, 2009) and invite to diverse self-biographical expressions (Munar, 2010). Often, communication about travel experiences on a social network is contextualised by personal information. On the other hand, richness of context may result in lesser reach, as users of these platforms limit circulation of their digitised content to friends and acquaintances. Increased richness of social cues thus brings electronic word-of-mouth closer to traditional word-of-mouth communication, which is still a crucial information source for travel planning and decision-making (Jacobsen & Munar, 2012; Schmallegger & Carson, 2008). Social cues (context richness) are often poor or restrained on tourism review sites, which are regularly characterised by anonymity of the contributors, even if unnamed reviewers may present themselves through place of residence, travel experiences and number of reviews. Compared with closed social networks, the reach of many of these platforms is wide. For example, TripAdvisor has more or less global reach, even if there are some language barriers. Research has indicated that lack of social cues (especially source information) impacts negatively on the perception of credibility of online reviews compared with traditional word-of-mouth (Dellarocas as cited in Ye, Law, & Gu, 2009). What is more, Gretzel and Yoo (as cited in Ye et al., 2009) suggest that online travel reviews are often perceived as more likely to provide reliable information than content posted by tourism organisations. This may partly result from what has been called “wisdom of the crowd” (Surowiecki, 2004).

The sharing of travel information by blogging has received broad attention from tourism researchers (Enoch & Grossman, 2010; Huang, Chou, & Lin, 2010; Mack, Blose, & Pan, 2008; Schmallegger & Carson, 2008; Tussyadiah & Fesenmaier, 2008; Volo, 2010; Wenger, 2008). Blogs became in vogue at the millennium and can have dissimilar levels of reach, from a few readers to many thousands. However, blogs seem not to be as credible as direct word-of-mouth (Mack et al., 2008) and the quality of tourists' contributions on this medium has been questioned (Volo, 2010; Wenger, 2008). Also, microblogging is a popular form of social media communication and news broadcast, enhancing immediate and real-time communication (Munar, 2010; Zarrella, 2010).

By sharing their knowledge, some of those who may be called e-fluent tourists (Bronner & de Hoog, 2011; Sen & Lerman, 2007) appear as free revealing innovators expressing some of the values of virtual community cultures (Von Hippel, 2005). Although tourists contribute free of charge to social media platforms, shared information may have high commercial value. TripAdvisor and similar review sites benefit from tourists' emerging communities by exploiting their user-generated contributions commercially. While tourism e-intermediaries increasingly benefit from the wide pool of knowledge created by tourists, many traditional suppliers such as hospitality firms and tourism attractions feel anxious about the impact of tourists' recommendations and demotions (O'Connor, 2010).

The influence of tourism information sources habitually depends on how trustworthy they become (Brogan & Smith, 2009). Traditional mass media value creation is based on the generalisation of "influence", either based on rationally motivated trust, moral insight or aesthetic judgment (Habermas, 1989). Communicative media entail either cognitively specialised influence (for example, through sharing of knowledge in wikis or blogs) or normatively specialised influence (for example, information about what is good and bad about hospitality services, in TripAdvisor) (Habermas, 1989). Active contributors to online media have also been categorised as "trust agents", accumulating social capital by building Web-based relationships and networks (Brogan & Smith, 2009). Social cues such as access to a reviewer's personal profile may impact on perceived trustworthiness of travel-related advice (Smith, Menon, & Sivakumar, 2005). Trust may also be affected by the social media sites where information is posted (Gretzel & Yoo as cited in Bronner & de Hoog, 2011). Somewhat likewise, trust in business websites is habitually related to successful corporate branding (Gefen, 2000).

Additionally, social media also entails capitalisation of *emotional influence*. Digitisation and sharing of feelings has been called "broadcasting culture" (Buss & Strauss, 2009) or "culture of exposure" (Munar, 2010). Although socio-emotional communication may be easier face to face, it is as well common and successful in digital media as well (Baym, 2010). Tourists may, for example, use emoticons to signal happiness or informal language to talk about their feelings. The emotional dimension of social media has expanded a "techspressive" (Kozinets, 2008) perspective of Web technical systems, considering technology a provider of individual realisation, mediated pleasure and escape.

Trust may also depend on the richness of context and social cues. Since these differ greatly between social media types (e.g. social networks, microblogging or review

sites), type of media may also have a relevant impact on willingness to create and share knowledge. This study thus examines perceived trustworthiness levels of selected types of Internet-based information, including electronic social media. Moreover, the study includes tourists' content creation and sharing in four main types of social media sites: social networks (e.g. Facebook), microblogging sites (e.g. Twitter), blogging sites (e.g. Travelblog) and review sites (e.g. TripAdvisor).

Methodology

Sample

Participants in this study are Danish- and Norwegian-speaking holidaymakers who were passengers on selected international direct scheduled (non-charter) flights returning from Mallorca to Denmark and Norway. Scheduled flights are the most frequent form of air transport to Mallorca, accounting for 75% of total arrivals in 2009 (Conselleria de Turisme, 2009). The survey was carried out on 6 selected days, mixing different days of the week, from 10 July to 7 August 2010, and it consequently covers the peak summer holiday period for Scandinavians, from the end of June until early August. Each day usually included three different flights. An opening screening question was asked so as to recognise travellers in the target category. The potential respondents were then asked to fill in a self-instructing questionnaire, which was returned to the administrative staff.

The questionnaire was available in Danish and Norwegian, translated from an English original. Due to financial limitations, tourists from other Nordic countries were not included in the survey. The questionnaire items were partly selected on the basis of personal interviews with people of various ages, most of them with experience from summer holidaymaking in the European part of the Mediterranean. Also drafts of questionnaire formulations were tested on various people from Denmark and Norway and discussed within the multi-lingual and multi-national research team and with other travel survey experts.

The exact response rate among those who were asked to fill in the questionnaire is not known, partly because the numbers of passengers on the selected flights and their distribution in terms of travel parties were not known. Moreover, children were excluded from the sample but numbers of children on the flights were not known. The reply percentage was also influenced by the fact that couples predominantly filled in one questionnaire. Some 23 questionnaires were rejected because they were incompletely filled in. Notes from the survey staff indicate a response rate of approximately just over 45%. This is considered satisfactory since airport surveys typically have response rates between 40% and 70% (Rideng & Christensen, 2004). The effective sample size is 405.

Non-charter tourists were chosen partly because they represent a majority of arrivals in Mallorca and partly because they are assumingly more independent and organise their own holiday journeys to a greater degree than fellow holidaymakers going for charter package tours. The survey relies on self-reporting. As some questions relate to events well ahead of the interview occasion, there is a potential recall bias, that is, under-reporting and over-reporting. However, it is likely that possible under-reporting

and over-reporting would be evenly distributed between assessments of various social media and information sources. Then again, possible under-reporting and over-reporting for reasons of social desirability might have occurred (May, 2001).

In order to reduce sampling error, stratification was employed. The basis for stratification was certain previous knowledge of air traffic structure, that is, departures of direct flights from Mallorca to Denmark and Norway. The selected procedure, encompassing a limited number of scheduled flights on selected dates, still represents sampling error (Hurst, 1994). However, by distributing data collection over a period of four weeks and varying the days, the sampling error for this study was reduced.

Table 1 provides key characteristics of the sample. Some 41% of the respondents were first-time visitors to Mallorca, and 49% had stayed more than 1 week in the study area.

Half of the tourists have a higher education, while quite a few were too young to have started at university or college. Half of the sample had bought only an air ticket while the other half had purchased some kind of tour package including air ticket and accommodation. Some 75% stayed in hotels or similar, 17% resided in a holiday home, 4% stayed with relatives or friends, while 4% made use of other types of overnight lodgings. Moreover, three out of four tourists have a Facebook profile (Table 1), indicating familiarity with social media and regular computer and Internet use. The mean travel party size was 4.2 persons. The mean age of the respondents was 35 years; the median was 36 years of age.

Measurement

The overall purpose of the study is to map perceived trustworthiness of selected Web 1.0 and Web 2.0 information sources, and to explore use of and contributions to electronic social media among Scandinavian summer holidaymakers in the island of Mallorca, adopting a multiple platform approach.

The holidaymakers were asked to assess the trustworthiness of a number of travel information sources on a scale from 0 ("very unreliable") to 4 ("very reliable"). The sources included were acquaintances on Facebook or similar networks; group(s) on Facebook or similar; tourist blogs; Twitter/microblogs; review websites with guest evaluations such as TripAdvisor; airline websites; tour operator/agency websites; hotel/apartment websites and websites of Spanish tourism organisations.

Moreover, the travellers were asked about possible contributions or media reports about their holiday tour, whether or not they have reported already or plan to report through the following four main types of electronic social media sites: make a photo album, video and/or diary for acquaintances on Facebook or similar; make a blog/photo album/video/diary on the Internet for all to see; tell on Twitter; write assessment(s) on a review site such as TripAdvisor or Hotels.com and tell acquaintances by email/sms/mms. These types of social media have been regarded as highly influential and have received much attention in academic research.

Respondents were also asked a generic question about the possible importance of information from electronic social media for certain holiday decision aspects other than destination choice and rate their answers on a five-point Likert scale ranging from 0 ("unimportant") to 4 ("very important"). The elements were "choice of

Table 1. Selected respondent characteristics (percentages) ($N = 399-405$).

Gender	
Female	55
Male	45
Educational level	
Primary school	21
Secondary education	30
University/college	50
Duration of stay in study area	
Up to one week	51
8–14 days	46
More than two weeks	3
Experience with study area	
First visit	41
Once before	26
Twice or more before	33
Internet purchase	
Whole or part of holiday tour purchased on the Internet	95
No Internet purchase	5
Use of information from social media for present holiday tour	
Yes	24
No	76
Facebook profile	
Yes	75
No	25
Use of Internet during present holiday	
Yes	60
No	40

accommodation (hotel, etc.), “choice of activities at destination”, “choice of eating places” and “choice of tour operator/agency (if package tour)”.

Other questions included use of electronic social media for the present tour, use of Internet during the holiday stay, whether or not they had bought a tour package, and Internet purchases of parts of the holiday services. The holidaymakers were also asked about their possible affiliation with the social networking site Facebook, the foremost social networking site in Scandinavia at the time of the survey. They were also asked about their familiarity with the destination area. Moreover, the inquiry included

customary demographic variables such as gender, year of birth and education. The simplicity that characterises most of the survey instrument resulted from interview time constraints.

The chi-square statistic (χ^2) is employed in order to test the statistical significance of the observed association in cross-tabulations, and the *t*-test is employed to see possible associations between continuous outcome variables (mean scores) and categorical determining variables. Only differences that are statistically significant at the 0.05% level ($p < 0.05$) are reported.

Results

A majority of Mallorca tourists who are users of electronic social media do not find these media relevant for their travel decisions. Among those who had used social media for decisions regarding their tour, 18% found such media quite important or very important for accommodation choice, representing only 7% of the total sample. Moreover, among those who had used social media for the tour, 9% regarded these media as important for choice of the tour operator or travel agency (if package tour). Some 15% found information from social media to be important for choice of eating places in Mallorca, and the same proportion found social media to be important for choice of activities during their stay in the island (Table 2).

In general, electronic social media are not perceived as being very trustworthy information sources by these holidaymakers (Table 3). Review sites such as TripAdvisor achieved the highest level of trust (mean score of 2.4 on a scale from 0 to 4). Among the most trustworthy social media sources in the eyes of the tourists are also social networks such as Facebook. Microblogging sites including Twitter scored lowest on trust among the information sources included in the survey.

Among Web 1.0 sources, hotel/apartment websites are seen as the most trustworthy, followed by airline websites and tour operator/agency websites. Websites of destination management organisations scored considerably lower and were perceived as being nearly on the same level as tourist blogs (Table 3).

Those holidaymakers who made use of electronic social media for their tour find social networks with limited reach and extensive social cues (i.e. acquaintances on

Table 2. Importance of information from social media for aspects of travel decisions, among users of social media, percentages and mean scores (scale 0–4).

	Unimportant (0)	(1)	Neither/nor (2)	(3)	Very important (4)	Mean score	<i>N</i>
Accommodation	44	7	32	9	8	1.3	154
Tour operator/ agency	51	5	36	5	4	1.1	151
Eating places	47	8	30	10	5	1.2	153
Activities during stay	46	9	30	10	5	1.2	152

Table 3. Visitor assessment of trustworthiness of travel information sources, percentages and mean scores (scale 0–4).

	Very unreliable (0)	(1)	Neither/ nor (2)	(3)	Very reliable (4)	Mean score	N
Acquaintances on Facebook, etc.	8	8	58	16	10	2.1	303
Group(s) on Facebook, etc.	15	11	63	7	3	1.7	298
Tourist blogs	16	10	57	14	4	1.8	300
Twitter, microblogs	25	9	64	2	–	1.4	292
Websites w guest evaluations (TripAdvisor, etc.)	8	8	35	37	12	2.4	313
Airline websites	6	9	45	27	14	2.3	318
Tour operator/agency websites	8	8	44	29	11	2.3	315
Hotel/apartment websites	5	9	38	33	15	2.4	320
Websites of Spanish tourism organisations	14	10	52	17	7	1.9	306

Facebook and similar) to be more trustworthy than those who have not used such media. Also, repeat visitors regard social networks with limited reach (acquaintances on Facebook and similar) as more trustworthy than do first timers in Mallorca. Conversely, repeaters find websites of destination management organisations (DMO) to be less trustworthy than do first-time visitors (Table 4). However, despite being statistically significant, these differences are quite small.

As far as tourists' age is concerned, there are few and quite small differences in evaluation of perceived trustworthiness of travel information sources. The older respondents (above 35 years of age) regard microblogging sites and DMO sites to be more trustworthy than do the younger holidaymakers (Table 4).

There are also few and quite small differences when it comes to type of holiday organisations (tour package or not) in evaluation of trustworthiness. Tourists, who bought a holiday package, find Web 1.0 sources to be more reliable than do independent travellers.

There were hardly any differences in perception of trustworthiness of information sources in relation to the tourists' educational level: A small difference that was nearly significant was revealed for review sites (Table 4).

It was uncovered that the most frequent channel for sharing digitised information is not through electronic social media sites but by means of short message services (sms/mms) or email systems, typically with limited reach. At the time of departure from Mallorca, only very few tourists had already dispatched media reports about their tour by means of mobile phones (sms/mms) and email (Table 5). However, as many as 36% planned to create and share digitised content about their holidays through social networks with limited accessibility (Facebook or similar) (Table 5).

Table 4. Visitor assessment of trustworthiness of travel information sources, mean scores, scale 0–4 ($N = 298–320$).

	Use of social media for tour		Experience with Mallorca		Age		Higher education		Tour type	
	Yes	No	First time	Been before	Up to 35	36 or older	No	Yes	Flight only	Package
Acquaintances on Facebook, etc.	2.3	2.1*	2.0	2.2*	2.2	2.1	2.1	2.1	2.2	2.1
Group(s) on Facebook, etc.	1.8	1.7	1.7	1.7	1.7	1.8	1.7	1.8	1.7	1.7
Tourist blogs	1.8	1.8	1.9	1.8	1.8	1.9	1.8	1.9	1.8	1.8
Twitter, microblogs	1.4	1.5	1.4	1.4	1.3	1.6*	1.4	1.5	1.5	1.4
Websites w guest evaluations (TripAdvisor, etc.)	2.4	2.4	2.4	2.4	2.4	2.4	2.3	2.5**	2.3	2.4
Airline websites	2.3	2.4	2.3	2.4	2.3	2.4	2.3	2.3	2.2	2.4*
Tour operator/agency websites	2.3	2.3	2.3	2.3	2.2	2.3	2.3	2.2	2.1	2.4*
Hotel/apartment websites	2.5	2.4	2.5	2.4	2.4	2.5	2.4	2.4	2.3	2.6*
Websites Spanish tourism organisations	1.9	1.9	2.1	1.8*	1.8	2.1*	1.9	2.0	2.0	1.9

*Statistically significant difference, calculated by t -test ($p < 0.05$).

**Difference with respect to education is nearly significant ($p < 0.089$).

Table 5. Possible media reports about the holiday tour (percentages).

	Have done already	Will do	Will not/not relevant	N
Photo album/video/diary for acquaintances, on Facebook, etc.	5	36	60	373
Blog/photo album/video/diary on Internet, for all to see	2	10	88	358
Tell on Twitter	1	3	96	360
Write assessment(s) on website (TripAdvisor, Hotels.com, etc.)	2	11	87	362
Tell acquaintances by email/sms/mms	26	39	34	379

In comparison, only 12% would share digitised content about their holiday with free public access on the Web. Some 13% of the tourists had already posted or planned to write assessments on review sites such as TripAdvisor. Twitter is the least popular social media channel, to which only 4% of these Mallorca visitors would contribute (Table 5).

Among these holidaymakers in Mallorca, most contributions to social media platforms did not happen in real time but would be done after they have returned home.

Table 6. Possible media reports about the holiday tour, have done already (percentages).

	Use of social media for tour		Experience with Mallorca		Age		Higher education		N
	Yes	No	First time	Been before	Up to 35	36 or older	No	Yes	
Photo album/video/diary for acquaintances, on Facebook, etc.	10	2*	3	6	6	3*	6	3*	15–17
Blog/photo album/video/diary on Internet, for all to see	5	1*	1	2	2	2	3	1	7
Tell on Twitter	2	1	1	1	1	1	2	1	4
Write assessment(s) on website (TripAdvisor, Hotels.com, etc.)	3	1	1	2	2	2	3	1	6
Tell acquaintances by email/sms/mms	38	23*	26	27	31	23*	29	24	96–100

*Statistically significant difference, calculated by chi-square ($p < 0.05$).

Table 7. Possible media reports about the holiday tour, will do (percentages).

	Use of social media for tour		Experience with Mallorca		Age		Higher education		<i>N</i>
	Yes	No	First time	Been before	Up to 35	36 or older	No	Yes	
Photo album/video/diary for acquaintances, on Facebook, etc.	55	30*	45	32	53	19*	44	28*	129–134
Blog/photo album/video/diary on Internet, for all to see	17	8*	12	9	16	4*	13	7	35–37
Tell on Twitter	5	3	3	4	4	2	4	2	10–12
Write assessment(s) on website (TripAdvisor, Hotels.com, etc.)	12	11	10	12	8	14	10	13	38–40
Tell acquaintances by email/sms/mms	37	40	40	40	43	37*	40	38	143–149

*Statistically significant difference, calculated by chi-square ($p < 0.05$).

Some 26% of the tourists state that they had already shared information, making use of emails, sms or mms, before they departed from the destination. Typical to most tourists who report real-time communication is that they have also used social media for the present tour, such as posting on Facebook or similar for acquaintances ($\chi^2 = 35.26$, $df = 2$, $p < 0.001$), posting on the Internet for all to see ($\chi^2 = 11.23$, $df = 2$, $p < 0.004$) and telling acquaintances by email, sms and/or mms ($\chi^2 = 8.13$, $df = 2$, $p < 0.017$). Tourists who report real-time communication also belong to a larger extent to the youngest half of the respondents when it comes to activities such as posting photos, videos or diary on Facebook or similar for acquaintances ($\chi^2 = 47.68$, $df = 2$, $p < 0.001$) and telling acquaintances by way of email, sms and/or mms ($\chi^2 = 8.58$, $df = 2$, $p < 0.014$) (Table 6). Although being statistically significant, these age differences are quite small.

Of those holidaymakers who planned to use social media when they had returned home, a majority had also made use of social media for planning the trip to Mallorca. Tourists younger than 36 years of age and (still) without higher education are more active on social networks with limited reach and other forms of social media (Table 7).

Discussion and Conclusion

This study aimed at providing empirical evidence of tourist use of, trust in and impact of electronic social media platforms and other Internet-based travel information sources and expanding the knowledge base on technological mediation and emerging tourism

cultures in the context of travellers from countries with a high level of ICT adoption and use.

In this case of Scandinavian international holidaymakers travelling to a mainstream, mature and well-known destination, social electronic media are of low relevance for common travel decisions such as choice of accommodation and eating places. Results differ from previous research, suggesting a general importance of social media in tourism (Tussyadiah & Fesenmaier, 2009; Xiang & Gretzel, 2010) and also more specifically that online user reviews have a relevant impact on online hotel room sales (Ye et al., 2009). However, previous literature has also revealed national differences in adoption and use of social media (Gretzel et al., 2008).

Social media have been said to entail a threat to the power of traditional organisations (Shih, 2009). Nevertheless, this study shows higher perceived trustworthiness of information from Web 1.0 websites controlled by tourism organisations (e.g. hotels and tour operators). Results show a relevant diversity of trust perception among different types of social media (e.g. between review sites and microblogging sites). This indicates the suitability of adopting multiple platform approaches in tourism social media research. Previous research has indicated that social cues may impact on perceived trustworthiness (Smith et al., 2005). In this study, review sites such as TripAdvisor, a type of social media with weak social cues, appears as the most trustworthy type of social media platform. Reviewers are very often anonymous and social cues in review sites are much weaker than in, for example, social networks (Munar, 2010). In the case of sites such as TripAdvisor and Hotels.com, trust perception may be related to successful corporate branding of these social media sites (Gefen, 2000).

Despite poor impact of electronic social media on the decision-making processes encompassed by this study, such media are important as communicative channels for experience and knowledge sharing. Tourists in this study to a quite large extent create and share content about their holidays by way of electronic media, despite the low functional value and not very high trustworthiness given to information accessed through social media. This may be due to the emotional, social and community-building dimensions (Baym, 2010). Also, earlier research has shown that tourists' information acquisition may proceed in situations when it is not subject to any obvious functional benefit, for instance, related to the aesthetic pleasure that people might take in accessing and sharing travel-related information (Vogt, Fesenmaier, & MacKay, 1993). Additionally, tourist preferences for social networks with limited reach, access control and high level of social cues sustain this tendency, such as communication to friends and acquaintances through Facebook. In many ways, this seems like a technological transformation where social implications remain, from typical earlier travel authentication through picture postcards, photo albums and similar, utilised for many of the same reasons – as tools to confirm sustained social relations while away from one's everyday surroundings (Jacobsen, 1983) and to maintain or increase tourists' social and cultural capital (Bourdieu, 1984; Putnam, 2001). As indicated in earlier studies, electronic social media provide not only possibilities for e-commerce but also individual realisation, mediated pleasure and escape (Kozinets, 2008).

The Scandinavian tourists in Mallorca show highest motivation for sharing tourism experiences and knowledge on sites with both high richness of social cues and high levels of control over who can access the shared content (Hsu et al., 2007; Smith

et al., 2005). TripAdvisor and similar review sites get a high score for trustworthiness but these Scandinavian tourists' willingness to contribute to such review sites is low. Results suggest that trustworthiness may be more relevant for "lurkers" who only want to access information on social media sites than for "posters", who want to actively contribute by uploading content to the sites.

Despite possibilities for real-time communication embedded in social media platforms, most Mallorca tourists surveyed here prefer to share travel memories and information about their tour when they have returned home, possibly because they want to make the most of their time at the destination. Results thus indicate an overestimated "real-time" effect in some previous social media literature (Qualman, 2009). However, mobile technologies help "real-time" sharing and this tendency is most prevalent among youngsters. The pleasure of anticipation is regarded as a pivotal aspect of holiday travel (Parrinello, 1993) and the present study brings to mind a comparable feature: the pleasure of recollection – reviving holiday experiences after returning home (Schade & Hahn, 1969). Also, several other scholars have mentioned the importance of the after-life of tourism (Haldrup & Larsen, 2010) or what Jafari (1987) characterises as the incorporation component of tourism. Creating, uploading, evaluating and sharing digitised content about holiday tours in social media is an active way to bring to life and expand memories of non-ordinary travel experiences into everyday life.

Results show a high level of adoption and use of email, sms and mms, as 65% of the Mallorca respondents have made or will make use of these technologies to tell about their holiday. These Web 1.0 technologies, which are not specific of social media channels (Zarrella, 2010), are also the most popular ways for tourists to let others learn about their holiday while still at the destination. One may say that photos and messages sent from mobile phones have become the new postcards.

This study shows only few and quite small age differences in social media adoption. In general, younger tourists have higher social media use and share more on electronic social media platforms. When it comes to evaluation of trustworthiness of social media channels, there are mostly similarities between younger and older tourists. The only differences are that the older tourists (above 35 years of age) find microblogging and DMO sites to be more trustworthy than do the younger holidaymakers. While younger tourists share more on social media characterised by emotional influence, control of access and higher social cues (e.g. Facebook), age differences are minimal when considering other types of social media such as review sites, where cognitive influence and normatively specialised influence may be more relevant. It is shown that the older half of these Scandinavian tourists in Mallorca is slightly more willing to contribute on review sites such as TripAdvisor than are their younger fellow travelers. Results indicate that several trends in technology adoption and use are cross-generational and that in the present context, generational patterns of technology adoption in tourism are highly complex and cannot be reduced to a digital versus the non-digital generation, as indicated in previous literature (Prensky, 2001).

Limitations and Future Research

Future studies may further analyse hedonic and socialisation values provided by these new media. Tourism scholars should also concentrate on the diversity of social media

cultures of different sites and examine dimensions of interactivity, reach, social cues (Baym, 2010), control and hierarchy while increasingly moving away from dualistic approaches (Litvin et al., 2008). Due to the high use of mobile technologies among such Scandinavian tourists, popularisation of smartphones with Internet access may possibly result in increased real-time sharing of user-generated content on social media platforms. But this could still be inhibited by the costs of mobile phone use in foreign countries.

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